Literary

- Tamil texts including the Sangam and post-Sangam literature.
- *The Arthasastra*, the treatise on economy and statecraft authored by Kautilya.
- The *Puranas* which mention the genealogy of the Andhras/Satavahanas.
- Buddhist Chronicles such as *Mahavamsa*.
- *Gatha Saptasati*, a *Prakrit* text composed by the Satavahana king Hala.

Classical Tamil Literature

The Classical Sangam *corpus* consists of *Tholkappiyam*, the eight anthologies (*Ettuthogai*), Ten Idylls (*Paththuppattu)*. *Tholkappiyam* is the earliest extant Tamil grammatical text dealing not only with poetry but also the society and culture of the times. The *Pathinen Kilkanakku* (18 minor works) and the five epics belong to post-Sangam times (fourth to sixth century CE) and describe a different social and cultural set-up.

Foreign Notices

The following Greek and Latin sources inform us about the long distance cultural and commercial connections.

- The *Periplus of Erythrean Sea*, an ancient Greek text of the first century CE.
- Pliny the Elder's *Natural History,* first century CE
- Ptolemy's *Geography,* second century CE
- A Roman Map called *Peutingerian Table*

Women Poets of the Sangam Age : Of the over 450 poets who contributed to the corpus of Sangam poetry about thirty are women. They composed more than 150 poems. The most prominent and prolific among them was Avvaiyar. Others include Allur Nanmullaiyaar, Kaakkaipadiniyar, Kavarpendu, Nalveliyaar, Okkur Masaathiyar, and Paarimakalir.

5.1 South India during Mauryan times

The Ashokan edicts (c. 270-30 BCE) present for the first time a picture of the political condition in south India. Rock Edict II lists the Tamil ruling houses Cholas, Pandyas, Keralaputras and Satiyaputra as neighbour rulers, lying beyond his domain, where he is said to have made provision for two types of medical treatment: medical treatment for both humans and animals. The Mauryan empire at that time included northern parts of Karnataka and Andhra, while the Tamil kingdoms were treated as independent neighbours.

After the decline of the Mauryan power, and before the rise of the Satavahanas, many small principalities emerged. Although not much information is available about their rulers, their coins and inscriptions reveal that they were chiefs who controlled small territories.

Ettuthogai and Paththupattu collections have about 2400 poems. These poems, varying in length from 3 to 800 lines, were composed by Panar and pulavar.

The Eight Anthologies are 1. Natrinai; 2. Kurunthogai; 3. Aingurunuru; 4. Patitruppathu; 5. Paripadal; 6. Kalithogai; 7. Akananuru; 8. Purananuru.

Paththupattu (Ten Idylls): 1. Thirumurugatrupatai; 2. Porunaratrupatai; 3. Sirupanatruppatai; 4. Perumpanatruppatai; 5. Mullaipattu; 6. Maduraikanchi; 7. Nedunalvadai; 8. Kurinjipattu; 9. Pattinappalai; 10. Malaipadukadam.

Patinen Kilkanakku texts, which are post-Sangam works, include eighteen texts, which mostly deal with ethics and moral codes. The most important of them are Thirukkural, and Naladiyar.

Silappathikaram and Manimekalai are the two important epics useful for insights into cultural and religious history.

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